



Airmail for Apple

Airmail is one of the smarter email clients available on iTunes and the Mac App Store for your Apple devices. <http://dgit.in/iAmail>



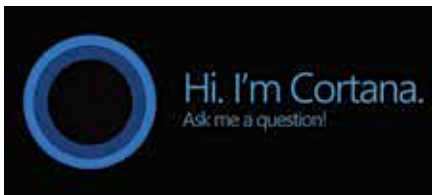
Livestream on YouTube!

You can now live stream videos directly from the YouTube app. <http://dgit.in/YTLivex>

you can specify your interests, and even remove those that Cortana detects on her own. It can also launch specific apps when asked and integrates into services like Foursquare to provide you information. Cortana also lets you set contact specific reminders which pop-up when you're communicating with the contact or depending on location as well. And if the thought of a virtual assistant constantly listening to you does feel slightly unnerving to you, then you can set do not disturb hours.

On PC, Cortana also integrates with Microsoft Edge to provide you features like Restaurant opening timings, reservations etc., on a restaurant website, coupons on a retail website etc. It has also been included into Skype as a bot to order food, provide info, transcribe videos and schedule appointments. On the Windows Mobile app, there is a constant effort from Cortana's side to keep the interactions within the app. For example, when we asked Cortana to book a cab, it showed us ten cab providers around us within the Cortana app itself, allowing us to ask Cortana to call one based on their position on the results.

On mobile, Cortana does indeed keep Microsoft's reputation consistent with the discrepancy in performance and setup process between its Android app (in early preview) and the Windows Mobile app. While the Android preview for India did not need



Halo-inspired Cortana is relatively new into the voice assistant category

any language configuration and automatically started with an Indian english accent and even told us Bollywood inspired jokes in Hindi, although it refused to understand Hindi itself. The Windows Mobile app, on the other hand, wouldn't launch with language set to English (India) and it had to be set to English (United Kingdom).

Cortana is expected to get a slew of new features with certain builds of the Windows 10 Anniversary update, and we can fairly say that the grounds are heating up.

Alternate platforms (Cars, Console)

Although the major focus of developing virtual assistants with voice recognition capabilities has been on smartphone developers, other product categories are also heating up when it comes to incorporating speech as an interface. One such category is connected cars, or more appropriately, smart cars. Even moderate range luxury cars had certain voice operated features since quite a while and the same goes for Bluetooth connectivity to your phone. Now, major software giants and car manufacturers are collaborating to create and incorporate operating systems for smart cars that enable them to be much closer to the virtual assistants that we are implementing on our phones. Android Auto, which works by connecting an Android phone to a compatible car, allowing you to use Google Now in your car. Apple wasn't far behind and had launched Apple Carplay with iOS 9 that essentially gives you the same capabilities with your iPhone. Both platforms have been picked up by a large number of manufacturers and soon, you will be talking to more than your co-passengers in your car.

Microsoft has also announced that Cortana is coming to Xbox. This opens up a lot more doors for voice interaction. Maybe you can pause your next Halo game just by asking Cortana to do so. This is in line with Microsoft's goal to unify the Xbox and the PC. And since Microsoft is doing it, we can expect Sony to catch up pretty soon.

A smart home wouldn't really be smart if each time you had to interact with it. Or you would have to deal with a mind boggling array of switches on a highly complicated panel, would it? That is exactly what makes home automation the perfect use-case for voice interfaces. Hence it is no surprise that Amazon's online store is actually running out of Echo. Its smart-speaker can talk to you, a number of apps and services and any smart device that it is connected to, thanks to Alexa, the onboard virtual assistant. Even Google has jumped into the fray and

announced Google Home, which sounds quite similar to Amazon's Echo. It is yet to be seen what Google's expertise with Google Now does to this product.

Beyond platform restrictions

Microsoft might have launched Cortana for Android and iOS, but there is no doubt

that it works best on Windows. Apart from that, neither Apple nor Google have truly launched their virtual assistants beyond their own ecosystem. So if you are looking for a platform agnostic virtual assistant to talk to, you might have to look harder. The Google Play store might have a few interesting options. We tried Assistant and it definitely has a sense of humour. Even though it is quite capable, the robotic voice and the multiple redirect to its internal browser with search results was quite dull, compared to the contextual results we get from the standard voice assistants.

Dag Kittlaus and Adam Chayer, creators of the AI behind Siri, have recently shown off their newest creation. Viv, a

platform agnostic virtual assistant is to be launched with certain third-parties towards the end of the year. It's more similar to Amazon's Alexa and Facebook's Messenger bots than Siri or Google Now in its integration with third party services. Their demonstration at the TechCrunch Disrupt NY in May this year showed Viv being able to handle fairly complex queries both in terms of breadth of AI and depth speciality. Due to their strength in AI and lack of a software giant's pressure behind them, they hope to get a large number of third party vendors on board and make Viv something as ubiquitous as Bluetooth or Location tracking currently.

With all these developments, and the opening up of Siri to third-party developers, we can only predict that speech as an interface is headed towards widespread usage. Because once it gets easy to talk to your devices from across the room, would you really want to play with buttons anymore? Do write in to us and let us know.



Amazon's Echo with Alexa will soon understand your emotional state as well